



THE ED HAS ALREADY TAKEN FORMER JHARKHAND MINISTERS EKKA AND RAI ON REMAND

September 2008, the agency failed to swing into action when businessman Choudhary was caught with Rs 6.14 lakh at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji International Airport terminal. He was detained for carrying more cash than allowed, but was released soon after. There are allegations that Choudhary and Koda's another trusted aide, Sinha, a tractor mechanic-turned-businessman, had a meteoric rise to riches because of their "association". The money Choudhary was caught with was also Koda's nest-egg. While Choudhary is the managing director of a Dubai-based Blue Techno Project and is said to own a coal mine in Liberia which the ED believes belongs to Koda, Sinha's empire is said to spread across dozen-odd companies with diverse business interests.

The questions that have emerged after the revelations relate to the efficacy and competence of the Central agency tasked to monitor and prevent money laundering, the manner in which issues have been overlooked and how the probe mechanism can be streamlined and made pro-active. It has brought little focus

THE STATE'S POLITICAL INSTABILITY ALLOWED INDEPENDENT MLAs TO UNABASHEDLY SCRIPT A STORY OF BOLD POLITICAL ENTREPRENEURSHIP.

The enforcement agency had been provided copies of documents seized by the vb probing disproportionate assets cases filed against six of them, all of whom have been charged under the Prevention of Corruption Act as well as under various provisions of the IPC related to cheating, criminal conspiracy and criminal breach of trust. "We are closely coordinating with the ED," IC (vigilance) M.V. Rao said.

Among these six tainted ex-vips, barring Koda, five of them were first-time MLAs, who benefited hugely from the fractured verdict of the 2005 assembly polls. While Shahi, Singh and Ekka carried the respective tags of the Forward Bloc, NCP and Jhar-

khand Party, they remained their own masters like the other Independent ministers, and the state's perpetual political instability allowed them to allegedly milk money.

Now questions like what the ED case actually means for Koda and his team have come to fore in the backdrop of a widespread belief that its intervention is a "conclusion drawn from evidences collected by the vb". The biggest challenge, however, for the ED sleuths is to establish a link between Koda and his frontmen to prove that the ill-gotten investments indeed belong to him. Beyond the probe, the ED's interventions appear to be a much delayed response. In

from the investigators who appear ill-equipped to study the dynamics of the constantly expanding corruption network.

Beyond the legal issues, the ED's belated move to pin the Independents is also being seen through a political prism. The Congress is anxious to disown those once pampered by it on the eve of the forthcoming polls. The Centre has already said that assembly elections would be notified latest by November 8, indicating that an elected government would be in place around Christmas. With elections round the corner, Jharkhand is again set to see politicians piling up loads of promises. ■